

MERFOLK



MERFOLK IS A MONSTER SUPPLEMENT FOR 5E THAT PRESENTS MERFOLK AS AN ORGANIZED UNDERWATER CIVILIZATION with a clear internal structure and escalating threat. Rather than treating merfolk as a single aquatic humanoid repeated across encounters, this book provides a full ladder of merfolk roles—from children and commoners to trench justicars and sovereign rulers—each designed to fill a specific function in underwater play.

The intent of this product is mechanical clarity and encounter variety within three-dimensional aquatic combat. Each merfolk type is built to support different kinds of scenes: reef patrols, coral gate defense, trench enforcement, hydromantic control, and layered vertical assaults. Cultural details, motivations, and moral framing are deliberately left open, allowing the GM to integrate these creatures into any setting, tone, or narrative without contradiction. Use these stat blocks as tools—how and why the merfolk defend, conquer, or govern the depths is yours to decide.

UNDERWATER COMBAT ON A 2D MAP



UNDERWATER BATTLES OCCUR IN THREE DIMENSIONS, EVEN WHEN REPRESENTED ON A FLAT GRID. TO SIMULATE VERTICAL space without tracking depth separately, use the following abstraction:

A single 5-foot square may contain up to **three creatures** — one at center depth, one above, and one below. These creatures are considered to be sharing the same horizontal position but occupying different vertical layers.

Creatures sharing a square vertically are adjacent to one another for the purposes of melee attacks, features, and abilities unless a specific rule states otherwise.

Merfolk are trained for three-dimensional warfare. They intentionally stack above and below enemies, rotate positions through shared squares, and use forced movement to pull foes into layered formations. When merfolk occupy vertical positions around a target, assume this is deliberate tactical positioning, not incidental overlap.

If more than three creatures attempt to occupy the same square, normal movement rules apply and creatures must move to adjacent spaces.

This abstraction keeps underwater encounters fast, readable, and tactically rich while preserving the essential advantage of vertical combat.

MERKFOK LADDER

Name	Challenge Rating	Description
Merfolk Child	0	Noncombatant youth. Used to establish stakes, civilian presence, or protected coral communities.
Merfolk Commoner	0	Baseline adult citizens: pearl divers, kelp farmers, artisans, and laborers with minimal combat capability.
Merfolk Coral Sentinel	1/4	Disciplined city guards who defend coral infrastructure using vertical positioning and fluid movement.
Merfolk Reef Stalker	1/2	Mobile hunters who strike from above or below and rotate through occupied space to harry intruders.
Merfolk Tide Channeler	1	Hydromancers who manipulate localized currents to control positioning and create vertical vulnerability.
Merfolk Deepwarden	2	Elite trench defenders who spiral around targets and impose sustained pressure in confined waters.
Merfolk Vortex Striker	3	Aggressive rotational specialists who accelerate encirclement tactics in open water.
Merfolk Coral Commander	4	Battlefield officers who coordinate layered assaults and tighten the rotational combat engine.
Merfolk Abyssal Arcanist	5	High hydromancers who reshape underwater terrain into controlled combat zones.
Merfolk Trench Justicar	6	Imperial enforcers who deny vertical escape and punish destabilized or encircled foes.
Merfolk Tidelord Sovereign	7	Rulers of coral metropolises who command entire encounters through hydrodynamic authority.

MERFOLK COMMONER

Medium humanoid (merfolk), any alignment

Armor Class 11

Hit Points 9 (2d8)

Speed 10 ft., swim 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	13 (+1)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)	11 (+0)

Skills Athletics +2, Perception +2

Senses passive Perception 12

Languages Common, Aquan

Challenge 0 (10 XP)

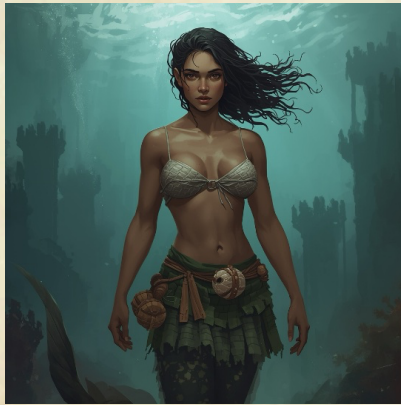
Proficiency Bonus +2

Amphibious. This merfolk can breathe air and water.

ACTIONS:

Spear. *Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack:* +2 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. *Hit:* 4 (1d8) piercing damage.

- Use commoners as vertical skirmishers: they attack from above or below in three-dimensional underwater combat.
- Position them around coral pillars or kelp forests so they can retreat behind full cover between spear throws.
- In numbers, have them focus fire on isolated swimmers rather than spread damage across the party.
- If defending a village, pair them with difficult terrain like reefs or nets to slow land-bound intruders.



MERFOLK VORTEX STRIKER

Medium humanoid (merfolk), any alignment

Armor Class 16 (reinforced coral war harness)

Hit Points 102 (12d8 + 48)

Speed 10 ft., swim 40 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	18 (+4)	18 (+4)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	13 (+1)

Saving Throws Str +6, Con +6

Skills Athletics +6, Perception +4

Damage Resistances cold

Senses passive Perception 14

Languages Common, Aquan

Challenge 3 (700 XP)

Proficiency Bonus +2

Amphibious. This merfolk can breathe air and water.

Fluid Interposition. While fully submerged, this merfolk can move through the space of another creature by swimming over or under it. It may end its turn in the same 5-foot square as another creature provided it occupies a different vertical position (above or below). A creature can share its space with up to two merfolk in this way.

Vertical Dominance. While fully submerged, this merfolk has advantage on melee attack rolls against a creature it occupies the space directly above or below.

Current Slip. While fully submerged, this merfolk does not provoke opportunity attacks.

Encircling Current. While fully submerged, if this merfolk moves at least three 5-foot squares around a creature during its turn (over, under, or around it), that creature has disadvantage on its next attack roll before the start of this merfolk's next turn.

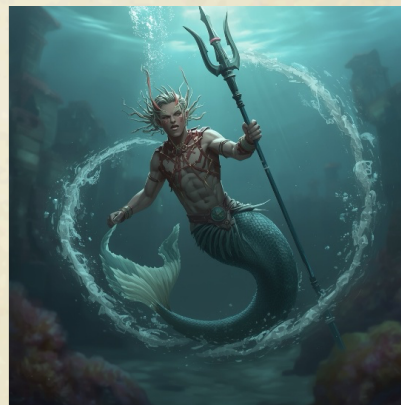
ACTIONS:

Multiattack (2). This merfolk makes two weapon attacks.

Trident. *Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. *Hit:* 8 (1d8 + 4) piercing damage.

Spiral Assault (Recharge 5–6). While fully submerged, this merfolk moves up to 20 ft. around a creature without provoking opportunity attacks and makes one trident attack. If the target is sharing a square vertically with this merfolk at the end of this movement, the attack deals an extra 7 (2d6) piercing damage.

- Use Spiral Assault to force vertical stacking before allies strike.
- Combine Accelerated Current with Encircling Current to apply disadvantage quickly against high-value targets.
- Vortex Strikers should operate in pairs, constantly rotating around the same creature.
- Avoid static melee; this unit's power comes from motion and layered positioning.



MERFOLK TRENCH JUSTICAR

Medium humanoid (merfolk), any alignment

Armor Class 17 (abyssal coral plate)

Hit Points 168 (16d8 + 96)

Speed 10 ft., swim 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
20 (+5)	16 (+3)	22 (+6)	12 (+1)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)

Saving Throws Str +8, Con +9, Wis +6

Skills Athletics +8, Perception +6, Intimidation +5

Damage Resistances cold

Senses passive Perception 16

Languages Common, Aquan

Challenge 6 (2,300 XP)

Proficiency Bonus +3

Amphibious. This merfolk can breathe air and water.

Pressure Adaptation. While fully submerged, this merfolk ignores difficult terrain caused by currents and has advantage on Strength checks and Strength saving throws.

Vertical Denial. While fully submerged, when a creature sharing this merfolk's space vertically attempts to move upward, this merfolk can use its reaction to make one Trident attack against that creature.

Fluid Interposition. While fully submerged, this merfolk can move through the space of another creature by swimming over or under it. It may end its turn in the same 5-foot square as another creature provided it occupies a different vertical position (above or below). A creature can share its space with up to two merfolk in this way.

Vertical Dominance. While fully submerged, this merfolk has advantage on melee attack rolls against a creature it occupies the space directly above or below.

Current Slip. While fully submerged, this merfolk does not provoke opportunity attacks.

Encircling Current. While fully submerged, if this merfolk moves at least three 5-foot squares around a creature during its turn (over, under, or around it), that creature has disadvantage on its next attack roll before the start of this merfolk's next turn.

ACTIONS:

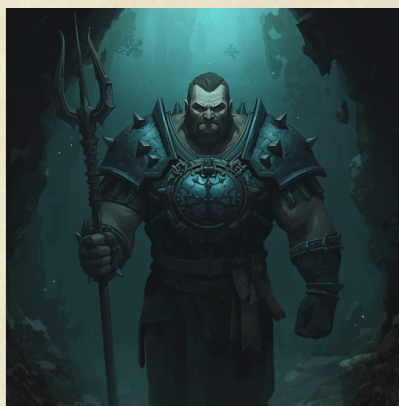
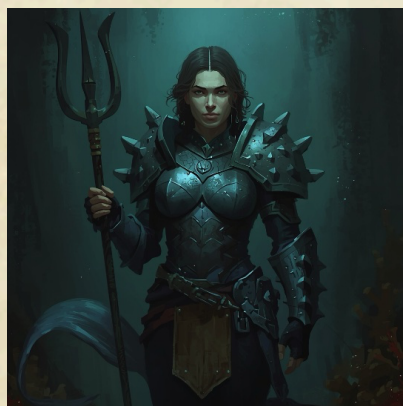
Multiattack (2). This merfolk makes two Trident attacks.

Trident. *Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack:* +8 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. *Hit:* 9 (1d8 + 5) piercing damage.

BONUS ACTIONS:

Crushing Spiral (Recharge 5–6). While fully submerged, this merfolk moves up to 20 ft. around a creature without provoking opportunity attacks. If it ends sharing that creature's space vertically, the target must succeed on a DC 15 Strength saving throw or have disadvantage on all attack rolls until the end of its next turn.

- The justicar aggressively uses vertical positioning and always attempts to share a square above or below a target.
- It circles enemies whenever possible to trigger Encircling Current before striking.
- It uses Crushing Spiral as soon as it recharges against the most central or heavily armed foe.
- It reacts immediately with Vertical Denial against creatures attempting to swim upward past it.
- It does not retreat; it presses pressure and positional control until destroyed.



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